SDLC at a Glance

The software development lifecycle from idea to outcome: what happens at each stage, the question it answers, and the tools that help.

Agile Lifecycle · From Idea to Outcome · One Toolbox

TEAM _____

DATE _____

1 Idea

WHAT HAPPENS

A problem or opportunity is raised and weighed against other work.

KEY QUESTION

"Is this worth exploring?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Product Vision Board
- Prioritisation Board
- Portfolio Kanban

TRADITIONAL GATE

Business case approved

2 Discover

WHAT HAPPENS

Understand users, the problem and the options before committing.

KEY QUESTION

"What problem, for whom?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Persona & Journey Map
- Opportunity Solution Tree
- Impact Map

TRADITIONAL GATE

Requirements signed off

3 Design

WHAT HAPPENS

Shape the solution into slices and stories, with examples and key technical decisions.

KEY QUESTION

"What's the smallest valuable slice?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- User Story Map
- Epic Breakdown Canvas
- Example Mapping
- Architecture Decision Record

TRADITIONAL GATE

Design approved

4 Build

WHAT HAPPENS

Write code and tests together, integrate continuously and keep work flowing.

KEY QUESTION

"Is main always releasable?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Sprint Planning
- Pairing & Mobbing
- Kanban Board Design
- Delivery Pipeline Canvas

TRADITIONAL GATE

Code complete

5 Test

WHAT HAPPENS

Automated checks on every change, plus exploratory testing for what automation can't see.

KEY QUESTION

"How do we know it works?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Test Strategy
- Example Mapping
- Definition of Done (Team Charter)

TRADITIONAL GATE

Test sign-off (UAT)

6 Release

WHAT HAPPENS

Deploy safely, then switch on for users at the right pace, with a way back.

KEY QUESTION

"Can we release, and undo it, safely?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Release Readiness & Strategy
- Release Forecast & Burn-up

TRADITIONAL GATE

Go-live approval (change board)

7 Operate

WHAT HAPPENS

Monitor, support users and recover quickly when something goes wrong.

KEY QUESTION

"Would we know if it broke?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Blameless Incident Review
- Delivery Metrics & Tech Debt
- Continuous Delivery Health Check

TRADITIONAL GATE

Handover to operations

8 Learn

WHAT HAPPENS

Measure the outcome, review what happened and feed the learning back in.

KEY QUESTION

"Did it make the difference we hoped?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Sprint Review
- Value Metrics
- Retrospective Kit

TRADITIONAL GATE

Post-implementation review

↺ *Learning feeds the next idea. In agile delivery the whole loop runs for every small slice, many times over, not once per project.*

Traditional SDLC and Agile Delivery

SAME STAGES, DIFFERENT RHYTHM

	TRADITIONAL (STAGE-GATE)	AGILE DELIVERY
Planning	Detailed plan up front; change is controlled	Plan a little, often; change is expected
Requirements	Complete and signed off before building	Discovered and refined just in time, with examples
Testing	A phase near the end	On every change, automated, from the start
Release	Rare, large and risky	Frequent, small and routine
Teams	Hand-offs between specialist groups	Cross-functional teams own the whole slice
Feedback	From users, after launch	From users, every iteration
Risk	Found late, when change is costly	Found early, while change is cheap
Progress	Phases and documents completed	Working software and outcomes
Governance	Document gates between phases	Evidence from working software, every iteration

Keeping Governance, Losing the Delay

- Keep the questions each gate asks, and answer them with evidence every iteration.
- Put compliance checks in the Definition of Done, not a final phase.
- Let the pipeline produce audit evidence: tests run, approvals, who deployed what.
- Review working software, not documents about software.
- Match approval to risk: small, routine changes go straight through.
- Invite risk, audit and security partners to reviews early, not just at the end.

"Where in our lifecycle does work wait longest?"

"Which gate could we replace with evidence from working software?"

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